

ADHD & LOVE

A Relationship Workbook for Couples Where One Partner Has ADHD

Understanding, Communicating,
and Thriving Together

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ADHD & LOVE

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HOW ADHD AFFECTS RELATIONSHIPS

ADHD doesn't just affect the person who has it - it affects the relationship dynamic. Understanding this is the first step to healing.

COMMON PATTERNS IN ADHD RELATIONSHIPS:

- Parent-child dynamic (non-ADHD partner becomes 'nagging parent')
- Hyperfocus courtship -> neglect (intense beginning, then distracted)
- Broken promises (not from lack of caring, but lack of follow-through)
- Emotional volatility (dysregulation affects both partners)
- Unequal mental load (one partner carries all the planning)
- Communication breakdowns (distraction during conversations)

WHAT'S HAPPENING (not excuses, but explanations):

- Working memory issues: forget requests, lose track of conversations
- Time blindness: chronically late, poor time estimation
- Executive dysfunction: sees the mess but can't initiate cleaning
- Emotional dysregulation: overreacts, can't let things go
- Dopamine-seeking: novelty preference affects attention to partner

THE GOOD NEWS:

- Understanding WHY eliminates blame and builds compassion
- Systems (not willpower) solve most ADHD relationship issues
- Many ADHD traits are ASSETS: creativity, humor, passion, energy
- Both partners have legitimate needs that CAN be met

THE ADHD PARTNER'S PERSPECTIVE

If you have ADHD, your experience in the relationship may include:

- Feeling like you can never do enough or do it right
- Shame about forgetting things your partner told you
- Frustration that you can't just 'be normal'
- Feeling micromanaged or controlled
- Defensive because you're constantly being corrected
- Wondering if your partner even likes you anymore

WHAT I WANT MY PARTNER TO KNOW:

- I'm not forgetting because I don't care
- When I zone out during conversations, I'm not ignoring you
- I WANT to follow through - my brain makes it harder
- I need systems and reminders, not lectures
- When you nag, I shut down (even though I know you're frustrated)

WHAT I TAKE RESPONSIBILITY FOR:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

WHAT I NEED FROM MY PARTNER:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

MY COMMITMENT TO THIS RELATIONSHIP:

THE NON-ADHD PARTNER'S PERSPECTIVE

If your partner has ADHD, your experience may include:

- Feeling like the only responsible adult in the house
- Exhaustion from carrying the mental load alone
- Loneliness (your partner is physically present but mentally absent)
- Resentment that builds over years of unmet expectations
- Guilt for feeling angry (because you know it's not their 'fault')
- Grief for the equal partnership you imagined

WHAT I WANT MY PARTNER TO KNOW:

- I didn't sign up to be your parent
- When I remind you, it's because I don't trust it'll happen
- I'm exhausted from thinking for two people
- I need to see EFFORT, not just apologies
- I love you AND I'm struggling with how things are

WHAT I TAKE RESPONSIBILITY FOR:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

WHAT I NEED FROM MY PARTNER:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

MY COMMITMENT TO THIS RELATIONSHIP:

COMMUNICATION BREAKDOWN PATTERNS

PATTERN 1: The Nag Cycle

Partner A asks -> Partner B forgets -> A asks again -> B feels nagged -> A feels unheard -> both resentful

BREAK IT: Use shared reminders/apps, not verbal requests

PATTERN 2: The Shutdown

A criticizes -> B gets overwhelmed -> B shuts down/walks away -> A feels abandoned -> A escalates -> B shuts down more

BREAK IT: Scheduled check-ins, time-outs with return time

PATTERN 3: The Blame Game

Something goes wrong -> A blames ADHD -> B says 'it's not an excuse' -> A feels shame -> A gets defensive -> fight

BREAK IT: 'The ADHD made this harder AND I'm responsible'

OUR PATTERN (identify your most common cycle):

It starts when: _____

Then I/we: _____

It ends with: _____

We could break it by: _____

COMMUNICATION RULES WE AGREE ON:

1. No conversations about problems when: _____

2. Time-out signal: _____

3. We come back to discuss within: ____ hours

CHORE WARS RESOLUTION SYSTEM

Chores are the #1 fight in ADHD relationships. Fix the SYSTEM:

STEP 1: List ALL household tasks

STEP 2: Each person marks: Love / Don't mind / Hate

STEP 3: Assign based on preference, not 'fairness'

STEP 4: ADHD partner gets external reminders for their tasks

MY TASKS (with reminder system):

Task: _____ Reminder: _____

Task: _____ Reminder: _____

Task: _____ Reminder: _____

Task: _____ Reminder: _____

Task: _____ Reminder: _____

PARTNER'S TASKS:

Task: _____

Task: _____

Task: _____

Task: _____

Task: _____

ADHD-FRIENDLY CHORE STRATEGIES:

- Body doubling (do chores at the same time, side by side)
- Timer challenges (race against the clock, not each other)
- Music/podcast while doing chores (dopamine helper)
- Lower standards for ADHD partner's tasks (done > perfect)
- Outsource what you can afford (cleaning service, meal kit)

TIME MANAGEMENT AS A TEAM

Time blindness affects BOTH partners. Build systems together:

SHARED CALENDAR (non-negotiable):

App we'll use: _____

- ☐ Both have access and ADD events
- ☐ Review together every Sunday evening
- ☐ Include travel time for appointments

PUNCTUALITY SYSTEM:

For the ADHD partner leaving the house:

- Set 'start getting ready' alarm, not 'leave' alarm
- Ready = keys, wallet, phone, shoes ON
- The non-ADHD partner does NOT manage departure time
(this creates parent-child dynamic)

AVOIDING 'ADHD TAX' ON THE RELATIONSHIP:

- Auto-pay all bills (ADHD partner should not be responsible for time-sensitive tasks without automation)
- Shared grocery/to-do list app
- Weekly planning meeting (15 min max, same day/time)

OUR WEEKLY PLANNING MEETING:

Day: _____ Time: _____

We will cover: calendar, finances, household needs

Maximum time: 15 minutes (set timer!)

EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & YOUR PARTNER

ADHD emotions are BIGGER and FASTER than neurotypical emotions.
This affects the relationship profoundly.

FOR THE ADHD PARTNER:

- Your emotions are real AND they're amplified by ADHD
- You feel things at 100% when the situation is at 30%
- You may say things you don't mean when flooded
- Cool down takes longer (don't make decisions while activated)

FOR THE NON-ADHD PARTNER:

- Their reaction is not proportional - that's the ADHD, not you
- Don't match their intensity (stay calm, don't escalate)
- Give space without abandoning (I'm here when you're ready)
- It's not your job to regulate their emotions

OUR EMOTIONAL AGREEMENT:

When I'm flooded, I will: _____

My partner will: _____

We'll reconnect after: ____ minutes/hours

Words I should NEVER say when activated:

RSD (Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria):

ADHD brains feel criticism/rejection as physical pain.

This is not manipulation. It's neurological.

How it shows up in us: _____

REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA

RSD is intense emotional pain triggered by perceived rejection or criticism. It affects 99% of people with ADHD.

WHAT RSD LOOKS LIKE IN RELATIONSHIPS:

- Overreacting to mild criticism or suggestions
- Assuming partner is disappointed/angry without evidence
- People-pleasing to avoid any possibility of rejection
- Withdrawing or rage in response to feeling criticized
- Interpreting neutral facial expressions as negative

FOR THE ADHD PARTNER - WHEN RSD HITS:

1. Name it: 'This might be RSD talking, not reality'
2. Ask: 'Are you actually upset with me or am I reading into this?'
3. Wait before reacting (give it 20 minutes)
4. Check the facts, not the feelings

FOR THE NON-ADHD PARTNER - HOW TO HELP:

1. Lead with reassurance: 'I love you AND I need to discuss...'
2. Be specific, not general ('this dish' not 'you never clean')
3. Separate the person from the behavior
4. When they spiral: 'I'm not rejecting you. I'm addressing this thing.'

OUR RSD PLAN:

Code word for 'I think RSD is hitting': _____

What I need when it happens: _____

What helps me come back: _____

REBUILDING TRUST

Trust erodes when promises are repeatedly broken - even unintentionally. Here's how to rebuild it:

FOR THE ADHD PARTNER:

- Stop making promises you can't keep (undercommit, overdeliver)
- Use systems, not memory (if it's not written, it doesn't exist)
- Acknowledge the impact of your ADHD on your partner
- ADHD explains behavior but doesn't excuse harm
- Show change through consistent SMALL actions over time

FOR THE NON-ADHD PARTNER:

- Notice and acknowledge improvements (even small ones)
- Separate current behavior from past resentments
- Allow your partner to rebuild trust gradually
- Forgiveness is a process, not a one-time event

TRUST-BUILDING AGREEMENT:

One thing I commit to doing consistently for 30 days:

ADHD partner: _____

Non-ADHD partner will: _____

30-DAY CHECK-IN:

Did it happen? ☐ Yes ☐ Mostly ☐ No

How does it feel? _____

Next commitment: _____

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 1

Date: ___/___/___ Time spent: ___ minutes

WHAT WENT WELL THIS WEEK (be specific):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT WAS HARD THIS WEEK (no blame, just facts):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU NEXT WEEK:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I APPRECIATE ABOUT YOU:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

SYSTEM CHECK: Are our systems working?

Calendar: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Chores: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Communication: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

ONE THING WE'LL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT WEEK:

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 2

Date: ___/___/___ Time spent: ___ minutes

WHAT WENT WELL THIS WEEK (be specific):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT WAS HARD THIS WEEK (no blame, just facts):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU NEXT WEEK:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I APPRECIATE ABOUT YOU:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

SYSTEM CHECK: Are our systems working?

Calendar: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Chores: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Communication: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

ONE THING WE'LL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT WEEK:

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 3

Date: ___/___/___ Time spent: ___ minutes

WHAT WENT WELL THIS WEEK (be specific):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT WAS HARD THIS WEEK (no blame, just facts):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU NEXT WEEK:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I APPRECIATE ABOUT YOU:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

SYSTEM CHECK: Are our systems working?

Calendar: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Chores: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Communication: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

ONE THING WE'LL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT WEEK:

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 4

Date: ___/___/___ Time spent: ___ minutes

WHAT WENT WELL THIS WEEK (be specific):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT WAS HARD THIS WEEK (no blame, just facts):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU NEXT WEEK:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I APPRECIATE ABOUT YOU:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

SYSTEM CHECK: Are our systems working?

Calendar: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Chores: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Communication: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

ONE THING WE'LL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT WEEK:

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 5

Date: ___/___/___ Time spent: ___ minutes

WHAT WENT WELL THIS WEEK (be specific):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT WAS HARD THIS WEEK (no blame, just facts):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU NEXT WEEK:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I APPRECIATE ABOUT YOU:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

SYSTEM CHECK: Are our systems working?

Calendar: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Chores: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Communication: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

ONE THING WE'LL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT WEEK:

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 6

Date: ___/___/___ Time spent: ___ minutes

WHAT WENT WELL THIS WEEK (be specific):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT WAS HARD THIS WEEK (no blame, just facts):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU NEXT WEEK:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I APPRECIATE ABOUT YOU:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

SYSTEM CHECK: Are our systems working?

Calendar: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Chores: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Communication: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

ONE THING WE'LL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT WEEK:

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 7

Date: ___/___/___ Time spent: ___ minutes

WHAT WENT WELL THIS WEEK (be specific):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT WAS HARD THIS WEEK (no blame, just facts):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU NEXT WEEK:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I APPRECIATE ABOUT YOU:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

SYSTEM CHECK: Are our systems working?

Calendar: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Chores: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Communication: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

ONE THING WE'LL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT WEEK:

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 8

Date: ___/___/___ Time spent: ___ minutes

WHAT WENT WELL THIS WEEK (be specific):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT WAS HARD THIS WEEK (no blame, just facts):

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU NEXT WEEK:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

WHAT I APPRECIATE ABOUT YOU:

Partner 1: _____

Partner 2: _____

SYSTEM CHECK: Are our systems working?

Calendar: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Chores: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

Communication: [] Working [] Needs adjustment

ONE THING WE'LL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT WEEK:

DATE NIGHT PLANNING (ADHD-FRIENDLY)

ADHD-friendly dates: Novel, active, engaging (not 'sit and talk'):

IDEAS THAT WORK FOR ADHD COUPLES:

- Cooking a new recipe together (novelty + activity)
- Mini golf, bowling, arcade (movement + fun)
- Taking a class together (pottery, dance, cooking)
- Hiking or biking (movement helps ADHD focus)
- Game night (board games, card games, video games)
- Food tour / trying a new restaurant
- Escape room (ADHD brains shine here!)
- Drive with no destination (ADHD loves spontaneity)

DATE PLANNING SYSTEM:

Who plans this month: _____

(Alternate months so one person doesn't always plan)

OUR DATE NIGHTS THIS MONTH:

Date 1: _____ Day/Time: _____

Date 2: _____ Day/Time: _____

RULE: No discussing problems/household stuff on dates.

This is CONNECTION time only.

DATES WE WANT TO TRY:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

ACCOMMODATION REQUESTS

ADHD PARTNER'S ACCOMMODATION REQUESTS:

(What I need to function, not excuses to avoid responsibility)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

NON-ADHD PARTNER'S NEEDS LIST:

(What I need to feel respected and partnered)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

OUR RELATIONSHIP AGREEMENTS:

We agree to: _____

Signed: _____ & _____

Date: ____/____/____

Review date: ____/____/____ (every 3 months)